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Transcripción de audio

IELTS Academic · Set 11

01 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 1: Reserva de un taller de fotografía

Agent: Good afternoon, Lakeside Photography. How can I help you?

Customer: Hi. I'd like to book a place on one of your photography workshops, please.

Agent: Of course. Can I take your name first?

Customer: Yes, it's Helen Whitby.

Agent: Could you spell your surname for me?

Customer: Certainly - it's W-H-I-T-B-Y.

Agent: Thank you. Have you attended a course with us before, or would this be your first visit?

Customer: It would be my first. I bought a camera about six months ago and have mostly used the automatic setting. The results are reasonable, but I do not really understand why one photograph works and another does not.

Agent: That is exactly the stage many participants are at. We keep the groups small, so the instructor can look at each person's pictures rather than deliver a general lecture.

Agent: Thank you, Ms Whitby. And your address?

Customer: It's 42 Redhill Road - that's R-E-D-H-I-L-L.

Agent: Redhill Road. And the postcode?

Customer: It's LS9 4RT.

Agent: And a contact number?

Customer: My mobile is 078 4421 9075.

Agent: Lovely. Can I ask how you heard about us?

Customer: I saw an advert in the newspaper - oh, no, sorry, it was actually a magazine.

Agent: Do you remember which publication? It helps us decide where to advertise next term.

Customer: It was a local arts publication that I read at the dentist. I initially thought it was the weekly paper because both use the same events page, but the course advert was definitely in the glossy publication.

Agent: No problem. And are you mainly interested in photographing people, buildings or outdoor scenes?

Customer: Mostly family events at the moment, although I would like to become more confident outdoors.

Agent: A magazine, great. Now, we run two workshops at the moment. Would you like to hear about them?

Customer: Yes, please.

Agent: The first is our Beginners' Workshop. You'll learn how to control the light - how much of it reaches the camera - and how to compose a good shot. The sessions are held on Saturday morning.

Agent: The instructor begins with the controls on your own camera, then demonstrates how position and direction affect a picture. Participants practise in pairs in the studio before going into the garden. There is a short assignment between meetings, but it is intended to build confidence rather than to be formally marked.

Customer: That sounds useful. I was worried it might assume a lot of technical knowledge.

Agent: No, we explain every setting from the beginning. We do ask people to charge their battery and bring the instruction booklet if they still have it.

Customer: That suits me well. I'm always free on Saturdays.

Agent: The second is the Landscape Workshop. For that one, the group travels out to a nearby lake and spends the whole day there. One thing to note - each student must bring their own tripod, as the light there can be quite low.

Customer: I've got one of those, so that's fine.

Agent: Good. That course is aimed at people who already know the basic controls. The tutor discusses weather, viewpoint and the use of filters, and there is time to compare images at the end of each day. Walking is limited to easy paths, but participants are outside for several hours, so waterproof clothing is sensible.

Customer: I enjoy walking, so that would not be a problem. Is there somewhere secure to leave a spare bag?

Agent: Yes, the group has access to a locked room at the meeting point. Expensive equipment should stay with you, of course.

Agent: Let me give you the prices. The Beginners' Workshop is four sessions of three hours each. It costs £120, and that price includes lunch.

Customer: And the Landscape one?

Agent: The Landscape Workshop runs over two sessions of five hours each. That one is £150, and the price includes transport to the lake.

Customer: Are there any other costs I should allow for?

Agent: Only optional ones. On the beginner course, drinks are included with the midday meal, but you may want to buy extra memory storage. On the outdoor course, you bring your own food, while the minibus journey is covered by the fee. We lend filters, but not cameras or stands.

Customer: And what happens if the weather is terrible on the outdoor date?

Agent: We still meet and begin with an indoor demonstration. If conditions are unsafe, the practical session moves to the following Sunday. We notify everyone by text before eight in the morning, so please make sure the mobile number you gave me is current.

Customer: It is. I think the introductory course is probably the sensible place for me to start, but I will check the dates before I decide.

Customer: Great, I'll think about which to choose and call you back.

02 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 2: Recorrido tras bambalinas de un teatro

Good morning everyone, and welcome to the backstage tour of the Regent Theatre. Before we set off, let me mention the improvements we've made this year. We've installed a completely new lighting system above the stage, which is now fully computer-controlled. We've also refurbished the dressing rooms downstairs, which the actors are delighted with. Now, some of you asked about the main auditorium - I'm afraid we can't alter that, as the building is protected, and the little café by the entrance is exactly as it has always been. The box office hasn't changed either, though we do hope to modernise it next year. The new equipment above the stage uses less electricity and can store the settings for an entire production. That means technicians no longer have to adjust every lamp by hand between scenes.

Below us, the performers now have better mirrors, ventilation and showers. Those two projects used most of this year's improvement budget. The protected seating area may be redecorated only with heritage approval, while changes to ticket sales remain a proposal for a future season. As we move around, please stay with the group and do not cross any yellow line. A rehearsal begins at midday, and technicians may be moving heavy equipment even when the stage appears empty. Right, let's begin. The Regent is a medium-sized venue and can seat 900 people. As we walk onto the stage, notice the floor - it's made of pine, a soft wood that has a gentle spring to it, which is kinder to the dancers' feet. The capacity includes the balcony as well as the rows below it; standing places are never sold. From here the room looks smaller than it does from the entrance because the upper seats curve around the sides. The boards beneath us are replaced section by section when they wear, rather than all at once. They are left unpainted for dance performances, although a temporary dark surface can be laid for a particular production. Please avoid the marked trapdoor near the centre. It is sometimes used for an actor's entrance, but today it is locked. The orchestra pit is covered as well because this week's show uses recorded music. Now look up. That tall space above us is the fly tower. Using a system of ropes and pulleys, the crew can raise and lower the scenery quickly between scenes, so the audience never sees it happening. Some pieces weigh several hundred kilograms, so only trained staff operate the system.

Each hanging piece has a numbered line and a balancing weight. During a performance, the stage manager calls every movement in sequence. A technician repeats the instruction before releasing anything; that simple exchange prevents one item from descending while a performer is beneath it. The space looks untidy during the day because several productions may be stored overhead at once. In performance, however, each movement has been rehearsed to the second. Just through this door is the green room. Despite the name, it isn't green - it's simply the comfortable space where the actors relax while they wait to go on. Next door is the wardrobe department. This is where a small team of skilled staff design and make all the costumes for each production, often by hand.

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Feature: in the event of a fire, a heavy safety curtain can be lowered to seal the stage off from the audience. It is tested before every performance. The large room at the back is the workshop, where the carpenters build the set - everything from walls to furniture. Construction starts from drawings supplied by the designer. The team first makes a small sample, checks that it can be moved safely, and only then builds the full-sized object. Most walls are timber frames covered with a thin surface; what appears to be stone from the seats may weigh very little. Paint and tools are stored separately, and extraction fans remove dust while cutting takes place. You may also notice numbered marks on the floor. These show where each item waits before it is taken onstage. Keeping that route clear matters during a rapid scene change. And finally, our tour ends at the theatre shop, where you can buy posters and other souvenirs from our current show. Do have a look before you leave. Thank you. The display changes whenever a new production opens, and signed items are kept in the glass case by the till. Photography is allowed in the shop and in the auditorium after the rehearsal has finished. If you have questions about technical careers, I will remain here for another ten minutes, and application leaflets for our volunteer programme are available beside the exit.

03 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 3: Revisión de un ensayo ambiental

Tutor: Come in, Maria. I've read your essay on reducing plastic waste. Let's talk it through.

Student: Thanks. I was a bit unsure whether my argument came across clearly.

Tutor: Well, your central claim is that individual action alone isn't enough - that governments and manufacturers have to take the lead. That came through very strongly.

Student: Good, because that was the point I most wanted to make.

Tutor: You establish it effectively by comparing household choices with decisions made earlier in the production chain. Your example of someone refusing a plastic bag is useful because it shows both the value and the limit of personal choice. The shopper can reduce demand, but cannot redesign packaging or require consistent collection across a whole region.

Student: I was careful not to suggest that personal habits are pointless. I meant that they work best when the wider system supports them.

Tutor: That balance is present. Keep the sentence where you say responsibility is shared, because it prevents the argument from sounding absolute.

Tutor: And the writing itself is clear and well organised. What impressed me most, though, was your use of real examples - the case study of the deposit-return scheme in Germany was excellent.

Student: I found that really interesting to research.

Tutor: The German case works because you explain what happened, rather than merely naming the policy. You show how a payment is added when a container is bought and returned when it comes back. You also compare the return rate before and after the scheme. That is more persuasive than a list of countries.

Student: I nearly used three short examples instead.

Tutor: One developed case is stronger here. The clarity of your prose and the overall length are both good, but neither is as distinctive as the concrete evidence.

Tutor: Now, there is one weakness. Some of your statistics are quite old - a few of your sources date back to 2009. For a topic that moves this fast, you really need more recent data.

Student: I did wonder about that. I found the older studies easier to access.

Tutor: I understand, but do update them. Also, I'd suggest reorganising the middle section. At the moment you present all the problems and then all the solutions. It would be stronger to pair each problem with its solution as you go.

Student: That makes sense. It would flow better.

Tutor: Exactly. Start with packaging that is difficult to recycle and follow it immediately with a design response. Then discuss inconsistent collection and the policy that might address it. Your current headings can remain, but each subsection will become a small argument rather than half of a long catalogue.

Student: Should I remove the paragraph about public information campaigns?

Tutor: Keep it, but connect it to labelling. Information is useful only if people can identify the correct bin and if the local service accepts the material. That link supports your central position.

Tutor: Exactly. One more thing - your conclusion is a little short. You introduce an interesting idea about consumer behaviour right at the end, but you don't develop it. I'd move that into the main body.

Student: I'll do that. What about the length overall?

Tutor: You are within the limit, so expansion is unnecessary. Moving the consumer point will leave space for a final paragraph that draws the argument together. In that paragraph, state which actors should act first and explain why. Do not introduce another policy at that stage.

Student: So the ending should reflect the argument I have already demonstrated.

Tutor: Precisely. A brief qualification would also be useful: national rules vary, so one model may need adapting rather than copying unchanged.

Tutor: The length is fine. Now, in terms of what to do next. First, you need to strengthen the evidence, so find some newer figures. Second, I'd like you to add a diagram showing how much plastic is recycled - a visual really helps the reader. Then check your referencing, because a couple of citations are missing a date. After that, read the whole thing aloud to catch any awkward sentences. And finally, send me the revised draft by email so I can look at it again before you submit.

Student: Thank you, that's really helpful.

Tutor: Before you go, set yourself a realistic order. Locate the updated sources first, because they may change a claim elsewhere. Make the structural revisions next, then create the visual once you know which comparison it needs to show. Leave proofreading until those larger changes are complete.

Student: I can do the research tomorrow and revise over the weekend.

Tutor: Good. When you read the draft, listen for sentences that run too long as well as obvious errors. Your final message should include both the document and a brief note identifying the sections you changed.

04 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 4: Los acueductos romanos

Today I'd like to look at one of the great engineering achievements of the ancient world: the Roman aqueduct. Contrary to popular belief, most of an aqueduct's length ran not on those famous arches but underground, hidden beneath the ground. The tall arches we admire today were used only where the water had to cross a valley. This arrangement protected much of the route from weather, accidental damage and contamination. An underground channel was also cheaper than constructing a continuous line of monumental masonry. Builders followed the contours of the landscape, accepting a longer route when it allowed them to maintain a gentle descent. Visible bridges were therefore solutions to particular obstacles, not the normal form of the system.

Engineers needed access after construction, so inspection shafts were placed at intervals. Workers could enter through them to remove debris and examine the lining without opening the entire route. The whole system depended on a single, simple force: gravity. Because there were no pumps, the channel had to slope gently downhill for its entire length, sometimes for many kilometres. If the slope was too steep, the water moved too fast and damaged the channel; if it was too shallow, the water stopped moving and turned stagnant. The required gradient could be remarkably small. Surveyors checked it repeatedly because an error near the source might not become obvious until kilometres had been built. They could redirect a route around a ridge or carry it across a depression, but they could not allow water to climb.

Planning therefore combined careful measurement with detailed knowledge of local terrain. At some crossings, enclosed pressure pipes carried water down one side and up the other. These were expensive and difficult to maintain, so an open channel with a steady descent remained the preferred solution wherever geography allowed it. To measure these tiny gradients, surveyors used a long wooden instrument, filled with water, that acted as a level. Getting the measurement wrong by even a fraction could ruin the whole project. The instrument had a sight at each end, and the liquid provided a dependable horizontal reference. An assistant held a marked staff farther along the proposed route while the surveyor compared its height. Repeating that procedure produced a chain of small differences.

The method was slow, but it was accurate enough for channels extending far beyond the city. Construction teams then marked the route and excavated sections simultaneously. Standard dimensions helped separate crews join their work with fewer discrepancies. The water channel itself was usually lined with a special waterproof cement to prevent leaks and to keep the supply clean. When the water finally reached the city, it was collected in a large tank and shared out. The most important users, receiving water first, were the public fountains and baths, where ordinary people came to wash and to collect drinking water. Distribution tanks divided the flow between several pipes.

Private houses could receive water under licence, but communal points had priority because most residents collected what they needed in containers. Continuous flow also flushed drains and supplied ornamental basins. The system therefore supported hygiene, recreation and civic display as well as drinking. Quality varied between sources. Officials might reserve a clearer source for

consumption and direct another towards gardens or cleaning. Settling chambers allowed sand to fall out before water entered the urban network. Maintaining the aqueducts was a constant task. A serious problem was the build-up of lime, a hard mineral deposit left by the water, which gradually narrowed the channel and had to be chipped away by hand.

The official placed in overall charge of the entire water supply held the important title of curator, a highly respected public office. That official supervised inspectors, labourers and records of legal connections. Unauthorised pipes reduced pressure and revenue, so the administration periodically checked private properties. Written reports describe damaged channels, disputed rights and the volume expected from different sources. This bureaucracy was as necessary as the original engineering: a neglected route soon lost capacity even when no dramatic collapse occurred. Eventually the system declined. In times of war, an enemy could force a city to surrender simply by cutting off its supply. And once the central government grew too weak to pay for repairs, the aqueducts slowly fell into ruin.

It was not until the Renaissance that engineers in Rome began to restore them, more than a thousand years later. Restoration did not simply reproduce every ancient line. Engineers selected routes that could serve the contemporary population and repaired surviving sections where practical. The renewed flow supplied fountains that became symbols of the city, linking a new public programme to ancient expertise. Archaeologists still study mineral layers, tool marks and repairs inside the channels to reconstruct how particular routes operated over time.